Hand washing is a vigorous, prior to rubbing together of all surfaces of hands lathered in soap, followed by rinsing under a stream of water. The purpose is to remove soil and transient organisms from the hands to reduce to microbial counts over time.

Purposes	1) Cleanliness, 2) Aesthetic, 3) Remove soil and transient organism, 4) Reduce the total microbial counts – over time 5 to prevent cross infection
Indication	1. At the end of each task 2. Before going into clean areas (or) handling clean articles 3. Before surgical procedure, delivery 4. Before serving or eating food 5. At any time when necessary

Situation for hand washing: GARNER and FAVERS recommend that nurses wash hands in the following situations.

1. Before contact with clients who are susceptible to infection.

   Ex: New born infants, clients with leukaemia clients who are HIV positive.
2. After caring for an infected client.
3. After touching organic material.
4. Before performing invasive procedure such as administration of injections, catheterization and suctioning.
5. Before and after handling dressing (or) touching open wounds.
6. After handling contaminated equipment.
7. Between contacts with client in high risk units.
8. After removal of sterile and non-sterile gloves.

Steps of effective hand washing

Step 1: Wash Palms and fingers.
Step 2: Wash back of hands.
Step 3: Wash fingers and knuckles.
Step 4: Wash thumbs.
Step 5: Wash finger tip.
Step 6: interlocking of hands.
Step 7: Wash wrists.

Guidelines for maintaining hand washing

1. Cut nail shorts to prevent accumulation of dirt.
2. Remove jewellery to ensure through cleaning.
3. Remove the wrist watch and push long uniform sleeves above wrists.
4. Respect the surface of the hands and fingers for breaks (or) cuts in skin and cuticles.

Medical Hand Washing:

Equipment:

1. Warm water
2. Antimicrobial soap/Regular soap
3. Clean towel

Procedure:

1. Remove wrist watch and push long uniform sleeves above wrists.
2. Avoid wearing rings.

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